



▲ DUTCH EAST INDIA COMPANY

In 1602, a group of Dutch businesses came together to form the Dutch East India Company, which was given sole right to trade with Mughal India (see pp.120–121) and the Moluccas (Spice Islands) of Southeast Asia. Within a few years it had set up its headquarters in Batavia (modern-day Jakarta), Indonesia, from where its vast fleets carried spices and other goods to Europe. It was also involved in the international trade of enslaved people. The company quickly grew into the largest in the world, with the power to raise armies, start wars, and establish new colonies in several parts of the world, including Sri Lanka, Malaya (Malacca), and South Africa (Cape Town).

The Dutch Golden Age

In the late 16th century, the Netherlands—then part of the Spanish Empire—began a long fight for independence. The Dutch Republic was founded in 1588 and, based on its people's unrivaled shipbuilding expertise and clever business skills, soon became a leading economic power. This prosperity brought in a golden age of Dutch culture.



The largely Protestant Dutch had first revolted against the rule of Catholic Spain in 1568. The war lasted on and off for 80 years until the Dutch finally gained their independence in 1648.

By this time, the Dutch Republic had become a formidable seafaring power with a strong navy, and a massive

merchant fleet trading spices and other rare goods around the world. Dutch merchants created the first central bank and stock exchange, and set up vast international trading companies.

The Dutch used their newfound wealth to build beautiful canal-side houses, and commissioned paintings from some of the finest artists in the world. This was also a period of scientific and intellectual discovery, with advances in astronomy, biology, engineering, international law, and philosophy.

◀ DUTCH PAINTING

Artists such as Rembrandt and Johannes Vermeer experimented with new techniques to paint realistic portraits, landscapes, and domestic scenes. Vermeer's "Girl With A Pearl Earring" (left) has inspired poems, novels, and films.